



Revving up momentum: Craig Fulton, coach of the Indian men's hockey team, has achieved his first major task: win the Asian Games and qualify for the Olympics. Now all eyes turn to Paris! M. VEDHAN

though I cannot comment on other leagues.

If you would like to incorporate anything from Belgium hockey in India, what would it be?

I will get some of the younger players from India to play in the European League. That will be a positive step.

I am looking to identify core players who can go to Europe. But it hasn't been discussed. It will be a good step forward to develop young players and get a faster learning curve for different tactics and styles of play.

What was your most memorable experience as a coach?

Ireland was special. It was nice to come back to the Olympics (Ireland qualified for the Quadrennial Games in 2016; the previous time it played in the Olympics was in 1908, when it lost in the final to Great Britain), put a plan in place, and qualify. We did it well.

In the 2016 Rio Olympics, we lost a close match to India and missed a chance to advance to the quarterfinals. And qualifying for the World Cup, we haven't done it for decades [Ireland qualified for the World Cup in 2018 after last making the grade in 1990]. The improvements and learnings from the Rio Olympics to the World Cup qualification were great. And to get across to Belgium, and then within three months, Belgium won the World Cup (2018) in India. That was a very good validation. From there on,

it was really enjoyable. Commuting was a big thing. I lived in Ireland and worked in Belgium. But on the hockey field, the friendship we forged was special.

You have travelled to various countries. What has been your basic approach to coaching?

I have worked in South Africa and Ireland, where communication was not an issue since everyone spoke English. However, when I worked in Belgium, things were different as they had two languages: Flemish and French, neither of which I was proficient in. When I came to India, I had to deal with a wide variety of languages, which was a new experience for me. It is more about creating trust first. Once you have the trust, it's about how much you care for the programme, what you are trying to achieve with the players, and what environment you